A CHRISTMAS GIFT COLLECTION

The Stories of Edward W. Pritchard

Twenty Memorable Tales of Family, Ohio, Nostalgia, Humor, and Heart

SELECTED WRITINGS OF

Edward W. Pritchard

“Stories from a life well-observed — of old banks, front porches, holiday mornings, and the quiet dignity of everyday people.”

AKRON, OHIO · CHRISTMAS EDITION · 2024

A HOLIDAY KEEPSAKE

TABLE OF CONTENTS

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CHRISTMAS DEDICATION

“To our family, dearest friends, and all who appreciate a good story told with warmth, keen wit, and honest heart. May these twenty selections from Edward W. Pritchard bring joy, reflection, and fond laughter to your Christmas season.”

01. **Christmas Club** *(Holiday Memory · The Dime Bank)* 3

02. **It’s a Very Good Story** *(Art & Faith · Siena, Italy)* 3

03. **A Door-to-Door Salesman Knocks Christmas Morning** *(Holiday Morning · A Quiet Visit)* 4

04. **Christmas Eve in the Emergency Room** *(Christmas Eve · Akron, Ohio)* 5

05. **My Sweet Velma Jean** *(Holiday Party · Young Families)* 6

06. **How Elmore James and My Father Integrated the U.S. Military** *(Family & Music · Guam, 1944)* 7

07. **A Long Time Ago** *(Neighborhood Memories · Junior High, 1946)* 8

08. **Labor Day Family Reunion Picnic** *(Family Reunion · Uncle Watson’s Farm)* 8

09. **How I Got Cured from Watching Too Much TV in 1950s America** *(Childhood Memories · O’Neil’s in Akron)* 9

10. **Late-Night Chats with Mother Knoppen** *(Neighborhood Life · Kitchen Whispers)* 10

11. **Speaking of Temporary Shelters** *(Boyhood Adventures · Lake Milton)* 11

12. **Crunchy Salt Pork Lilly** *(Depression Roots · West Virginia)* 12

13. **Back on the Road Again** *(Youth Travels · Southern Ohio, 1970)* 13

14. **Meteor Shower** *(Summer Skies · Midnight Watch)* 14

15. **The Good Policeman** *(Kindness of Strangers · Akron)* 15

16. **A Grandfather’s First Birthday Wishes** *(A Grandfather’s Wisdom · Quaker Square)* 16

17. **The Train Doesn’t Run to Gettysburg Anymore** *(Solitude & Night Walks · East Canton)* 17

18. **Lunch with the Phillips Family** *(Old-School Hospitality · Sunday Dinner)* 18

19. **Heavy, Heavy Snow** *(Winter in Ohio · The Industrial District)* 19

20. **My Lost Saints** *(Growing Up · Saint Francis & The Beatles)* 20

HOLIDAY MEMORY · THE DIME BANK · 2010

Christmas Club

We had a bank in town back then called the Dime Bank. Later I would open up my first savings account there, get my first car loan there, and after it merged with another Bank transfer all my accounts. But that was much later. When I was seven years old I learned about the bigger world from My Mother's Christmas savings account from the Dime bank in our hometown.

Each week Mom who didn't work outside the house would deposit five dollars into her Christmas savings account. It was a lot of discretionary money for our family for money was tight and it was tempting to use the money for other things and Dad often wanted to. Car repairs, occurring unexpectedly or a late mortgage payments, threatened Mom's Christmas account. But, no matter how skillfully or logically Dad protested and argued Mom won out. We never touched the Christmas savings before December 15th.

Each year one of us kids would take the bus with her downtown and she would with draw the 250 plus interest, making a total of about $263 that Mom took in cash, in small bills. Then off we went for a twelve hour day of shopping and hauling huge bags around; for Mom bought for everyone.

We didn't have much money when I was young but my family was generous and we always were shown a good Christmas.

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ART & FAITH · SIENA, ITALY · 2018

It's a Very Good Story

Christmas is hard for me here in my old age. One thing that brings me a little comfort this time of year is to listen to the entire story of Jesus not just the praise songs of his exalted birth in a stable a long time ago. Seldom do I read the Bible though I do lots and lots of reading about Roman history from the fifth century BC forward.

Last night I got one of my art books and carefully studied the pictures of Jesus' entire life in the paintings of the master of Sienna Duccio.

It's a very good story the record of Jesus' life. Duccio the Italian painter could be a difficult and rebellious man. The business people of Sienna went to great lengths contractually to tie him to the project they wanted him to do back in 1308. Duccio di Buoninsegna's work is called the Maesta, the Master piece and was displayed first, his finished project of the complete life of Jesus in pictures, to the public on June 09, 1311. The day was declared a holiday and the entire town followed the finished sacred work to the Church.

I saw parts of Duccio altarpiece once in a church in Sienna, Italy. The pictures are worth taking our time to study and meditate on.

The history of Jesus' life, it's a very good story.

HOLIDAY MORNING · A QUIET VISIT · 2011

A Door-to-Door Salesman Knocks Christmas Morning

It was Christmas morning and the presents had been opened and the house cleaned and my wife and teenage daughter had gone to mall to shop for half price items at a super sale at one of the women's clothing stores. I had eaten a large meal last night and was dozing late Christmas morning sleeping it off. We would have another large meal later this afternoon.

There was a light knock at the side door of my house near where I was sleeping in my reclining chair. The knock was faint but persistent. Having nothing else to do I answered.

At my door was a small looking shabbily dressed man maybe from somewhere in Central America. His English was bad but he was selling a broken down pair of high top brown boots. The boots had a tear where the toe and sole joined. The boots were of a small size obviously much to small for me. The man repeated the price in English several times. Six fifty. He also said the word dollars with the price, I was able to decipher. The man spoke in a heavy Spanish accent but the price in English, $ 6.50, was easy enough to understand. I said no to the sale and sent the salesman on his way.

A few minutes later very curious I went outside in a light snow to find the man. I didn't see the man selling the boots but I followed his footprints as he went from one of my neighbors houses to the next. Across the sidewalk up the walk to the back door at each of the houses in our neighborhood the Spanish speaking salesman had walked trying to sell the boots.

Eventually I lost the trail of the man trying to sell the boots. I had walked a long way from my house following the foot steps. I never did find the small Hispanic man selling the boots or find out if the salesman was walking door to door barefoot and carrying the ripped boots.

CHRISTMAS EVE · AKRON, OHIO · 2011

Christmas Eve in the Emergency Room

Dr. Lewis was too old to work nights in ER but tonight he was pulling a four hour shift on Christmas Eve for an old friend. Dr Lewis was sitting in the ER with the young RN on duty and she was wrapping Christmas presents for her children for Christmas. It was a slow night and Dr. Lewis who was once chief surgeon here and later, but before this Christmas eve night, was on the board of Directors of this hospital. Dr Lewis told the nurse she could wrap presents since they weren't very busy tonight.

About 4:30 AM a cab pulled up to ER and a young woman carried her three year old daughter into the reception area of ER where Dr. Lewis and the young RN were sitting and talking as the RN wrapped Christmas presents. The little three year old girl was barely breathing. Later, after the Doctor had diagnosed an asthma attack, the girl's first, which was scaring the Mother badly: Dr. Lewis wrapped the little girl in a blanket and took her out into the brisk night air to open up her lungs.

Dr. Lewis never admitted the young girl figuring that anyone who drove up on Christmas eve in a taxi wouldn't have health insurance or much money. Since the little girl was doing better Dr. Lewis let the RN leave an hour early so she could drive the young Mother and the girl with asthma home; which also would let the RN get home to her family about a half hour before her own children woke up. Dr. Lewis also gave the Mother a prescription for an inhaler, a couple of sample inhalers for now and refered the little girl to a colleague.

A memo about the incident with the young girl not being properly admitted to the Hospital was put in the Hospital compliance audit file but nothing ever came of the matter since Dr. Lewis was long retired and was once Chief Surgeon and later on the Hospital Board of Directors. The Mother of that little girl sent a thank you card to Dr Lewis and another to the RN. It took a while for the thank you card to get from the Hospital where it was sent to Dr. Lewis but after he got it, the card sat on Doctor Lewis' mantel for a long time.

HOLIDAY PARTY · YOUNG FAMILIES · 2011

My Sweet Velma Jean

I was at the office Christmas party for my wife Velma and she had went with co-workers to look at pictures to memorialize this years party and I was wandering a little bored around the company owners house.

Next to the kitchen, near two large walkout doors several young women sat on blankets on the floor each admiring a new baby. Out of duty to my wife more than curiosity I stopped to look at the new baby too. The new baby was a monkey. Dressed in a new pink outfit, several of the women were giving the new Mother presents for the baby, but the baby was definitely a monkey.

Later, but before I found my wife and before I got to tell Velma about the monkey, the Company owner's wife, our hostess here at the party asked me to help answer the phone for a few minutes which were very busy because customers were calling in to congratulate the employees here at the Company on another very successful year. I took messages and wrote down the basic sentiment of each call on a Company phonepad for about ten minutes.

When I went to where the pictures were being sorted Velma wasn't around. A couple of people were over at the piano playing Christmas carols; not wanting to sing I took a stack of the pictures from the table that were being sorted to find prospects for this years yearbook. As I walked around the house I leafed through the pictures.

Two of the pictures were definitely of Velma. They were taken from the front up towards her eye's and were of the compromising variety, involving a short length of white frayed clothesline style rope, but the pictures definitely were of my sweet Velma Jean. By now I had walked through most of the company owners house looking for my wife Velma but hadn't found her yet.

FAMILY & MUSIC · GUAM, 1944 · 2013

How Elmore James and My Father Integrated the U.S. Military

note- my Father would never discuss his military service, so this story has a lot of surmising in it, no proof exists to collaborate things.

Guam in the Pacific Ocean in 1944 smack in the middle of the air war against Japan. My Father then 20 years old was company clerk working in a Quonset hut on the edge of the jungle and he had a big problem. The company's radio was on the blink, there was no one to fix it since all the engineers were working on the bomber planes, the Captain was about to have the privates head [my Father], and drastic measures were necessary to fix the radio to allow the war effort against the Japanese from Guam to move forward.

That's how my Father Ed Pritchard Sr. US Air force company clerk came to meet Elmore James radio repairman US Navy. The radio was duly fixed by James and the two enlisted men became friends over a joint interest in music. Pritchard wanted to be a classical piano player and James played guitar, an electric guitar amplified by his own secret methods, across the American South before the war.

After a fight between white and black soldiers at the local off duty bar Pritchard, who studied piano and violin at University before he was drafted, found himself ordered by his Captain to play boogie boogie piano under the direction of Elmo James who had experience leading several pickup bands in the American South before the war. For several months Elmore James would sing and play backed up by my Father on piano as lonely white and black soldiers listened to the new style of blues music from the Mississippi delta. There were no more racially motivated fights among the American soldiers on Guam. Some credited it to the music played at the local enlisted men's club.

Later after the war both men would die early deaths from heart problems perhaps suffered from the stress of world war two, and neither received any veterans benefits. Elmore James strongly influenced world wide music in the 1960's although he never received top billing or star status and fame during his lifetime. Ed Pritchard sr., never became a classical piano player, but once in a while he fooled around with boogie woogie piano for his oldest son before his death in 1969.

NEIGHBORHOOD MEMORIES · JUNIOR HIGH, 1946 · 2011

A Long Time Ago

Two very elderly women are standing in front of a smaller brick house talking. Usually the younger woman, Charlotte, 81, wouldn't be outside but it was so sunny and temperate today that she walked across the two yards and knocked on her neighbors, Connie Flander's front door. It's 9:15 AM and already 87 degrees.

The two women are talking about Eric Jaggers again. Eric was Connie's boyfriend back in junior high school in 1946. One Friday night back then Connie caught Eric under the bleachers at the old stadium, now a Wal Mart, with Charlotte Johnson.

Families long dispersed and both women usually alone, the two women stood in the hot sun and talked about Eric Jaggers, disappeared from both their lives for 65 years and dead these last fifteen years.

"Eric had that wiry black wavy hair; he was part Greek", said Charlotte.

"I am sorry I slapped you" said Mrs. Flanders.

"You never slapped me, I blocked it with my hand" said Charlotte.

"Your hands were trying to close your shirt young lady", admonished Connie Flanders.

Both laughed, "Maybe true, I can't remember", said Charlotte.

Soon the hot sun drove both women inside their respective homes for the day. But soon again, the heat and warm will drive one of the two to knock on her neighbors door and talk again about the men in their lives.

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FAMILY REUNION · UNCLE WATSON'S FARM · 2019

Labor Day Family Reunion Picnic

Out at Uncle Watson's farm the boys were playing baseball labor day at the family reunion picnic. Forty matching casual chairs faced home plate in a large semicircle this year for uncle Watson had done well in the stock market of late and the tables back of cousin Mike the catcher were loaded with store bought fancy eats as well as every woman's here special concoction potato salad in a crystal bowl.

As the ball game was winding down a bit Etta Watson's neighbor 40 year old Mrs McDonald strolled over in a pair of yellow shorts bringing her neighbors her coveted chocolate fudge Brownies. Grandpa Howard who I was respectfully sitting with slowly stood up and sided over to Home plate grabbed the bat from cousin Mickey as the teenage boys smiled and glancing at Mrs.McDonald asked his great nephew Arron to lob him a curve ball.

With a crack Grandpa whacked the mushy soft ball clear past and over the barn he used to play in as a boy way way out in right center field.

"Run grandpa run I yelled".

Grandpa smiled at me and returned slowly to his seat and as he walked he said sort of to everyone " First is earned and second base is worked for as third base is given but home plate is never forgotten.

A little later I remember Grandpa sitting drinking a beer and my Mother grandpa's oldest daughter being a little bit mad at her Father.

CHILDHOOD MEMORIES · O'NEIL'S IN AKRON · 2019

How I Got Cured from Watching Too Much TV in 1950s America

When I was five my Dad was at work, Mom slept a lot, our other kids were babies and I got to watch a lot of TV. My favorite show was local programming originating from Cleveland about 45 miles north of our house there in Tallmadge, Ohio.

Captain Penny was host of a local TV show sometimes on twice a day. I watched the show religiously. Keeping a running commentary of folksy humor and old time advice Captain Penny would announce an episode of the little rascals or three stooges and now and then a cartoon. I watched the show five days per week for two years before I started to school.

Once as a treat for me, my Mother took me by bus downtown Akron to the O'Neil's department store to see the Celebrity Captain Penny in person. Turns out Captain Penny was different in real life than he was on TV.

We waited a longtime in a long line to see Captain Penny and our bus, the last of the evening was leaving in a few minutes so my Mom and I jumped line to see the Captain up close. Ignoring my Mom and without missing a beat with the kid he was talking to in the front of the long line the Captain looked down at me and said "back of the line Kid. He said it mean like with an unfamiliar glint in his eye.

That's how I got cured from watching too much TV back in the 1950's america.

To this day I don't watch any more children's TV and I don't quite trust authority figures.

NEIGHBORHOOD LIFE · KITCHEN WHISPERS · 2012

Late-Night Chats with Mother Knoppen

You had to be very quiet when you stopped by to chat with Mother Knoppen. The children were light sleepers and it took Mrs. Knoppen a long time to get them all in bed for the night. We would sit at her kitchen table to whisper late, after ten PM, and Angela Knoppen, Angie, would tell me about what she wanted to do someday. Study about space travel or join the garden club. Usually one of the seven children would have a cough or a nightmare and we would put the coffee cups in the sink, put away the Ritz crackers, and have to continue our talks in a couple of weeks.

Twenty years later I sometimes ran into Angie Knoppen over at McDonald's with one or two of her grandchildren. She would tell me about the newest theory in string theory and multiple universes. Usually as she talked she would forget about being a Grandmother for a minute when she was excited about Science or something and forget herself and brush back her hair with the back of her hand and maybe draw a diagram on the napkin there at McDonald's explaining how there might be eleven multiple universes. Before long one of her Daughter's would come in to tell her she was getting back with her husband or Mike, her boyfriend was on strike and we would have to discontinue our chat.

After I exited the McDonald's I would always stand in the glass entry way with the employee washing the double doors and watch Angie holding a baby and listening intently to the details of Mike's temporary job.

BOYHOOD ADVENTURES · LAKE MILTON · 2019

Speaking of Temporary Shelters

A girl from my neighborhood once told my wife at the time that I ran wild as a boy. It was an inappropriate but true thing to say for since I was four years old I often roamed the neighborhoods unsupervised and as uncivilized as Tom Sawyer or Huck Finn.

Once a friend and I were across the canal in the woods when we found a large old uprooted hollow tree stump with ice on it's floor one June day. The next day my friend couldn't return to our temporary shelter as he had contacted vegetation rash from the hollow tree. So I used the hollow tree as my cave house, scrapped some of the ice off the walls to chill my seven up drink and had several adventures throughout that summer with the old tree stump as a back drop.

A few years later I and some older guys hid out in the sticker filled gullies behind our grade school waiting for the workmen at the new apartments on the lake to leave after they finished installing about a hundred washers, dryers refrigerators and stoves. Patiently we waited to commandeer the boxes. Over the next few days we broke down the boxes and rearranged the packing crates to make a box city there in the swamp along the lake behind the new apartments. The central area of the box city floated precariously on the swamp and could only be reached by crawling through a very long tunnel of boxes to reach the living room which looked out on the lake. I was the last of the boys to leave the sight and the workmen threatened to call my dad the day they started to burn our settlement. My Dad heard about what happened with the box city and me trespassing but I didn't get in trouble because before my Dad was a soldier or worked as a rate clerk in the trucking industry when he was twelve my Father had played Tom Sawyer in the school play and got to kiss Becky Thatcher in the cave in the Mark Twain story.

My last temporary shelter was a downtown apartment near the University where I met a girl I liked. After that I was married and had four children who I tried to supervise closely so they wouldn't grow up to be wild or vagabonds.

DEPRESSION ROOTS · WEST VIRGINIA · 2010

Crunchy Salt Pork Lilly

Crunchy Salt Port Lilly

fiction edward w pritchard

You know your poor when you can't even afford popcorn. My Father's family came from Great Britain originally but despite the great intelligence of some of them they ended up poor down there in the small but beautiful mountains of West Virginia. One of their favorite foods was Crunchy Salt Port Lilly and it was the remainder of corn after all the useful parts had been used for other food manufacture for people and animals.

My dad's family had a lot of people in it. Ten people or so in the immediate family. They never all gathered together at the same time when I was a boy so I couldn't ever keep them straight and I was never sure if they existed at all. I only heard one sentence factoids of something extraordinary they had once done such as cut a candy bar in ten pieces so everyone could get a treat at Christmas. Another thing they used to do was gently tussle over who could eat the most crunchy Salt Port Lilly. It came in large 100 pound bags like oats for a horse might come in and in a couple of days for snacks my Father's family could eat a whole bag of those tasty morsels of Crunchy Salt Port Lilly.

Of course when I was a boy I didn't appreciate things and didn't like the dry hulky, husky taste of the dry hulls and remainder of corn and my Dad used to chastise me that I better learn to enjoy what I had. I always wanted a whole candy bar for myself. Having never grew up in the Great depression I never learned to value the simple things sent by god to the poor folks like Crunchy Salt Port Lilly.

Too bad because now I need to learn to be content with what I have. I have been outwitted by too many people who take and grab in a business deal like they had three rotating hands. Its a skill they learn in business school I think.

Anyway this weekend I think I am going to stop down West Virginia way and try to find a sack of that good ole Crunchy Salt Port Lilly. I think if I am careful a small bag will last me a long time for snacks and things.

YOUTH TRAVELS · SOUTHERN OHIO, 1970 · 2021

Back on the Road Again

Back about 1970 my pals and I would hitch hike to southern Ohio near the Ohio River, over towards Pennsylvania to fish or with little money for security clear up to the Canadian national road after spending a few days in Montreal. Money was scarce, but friends were easy to make then and we were rough and ready enough to sleep on the ground usually without a sleep bag. Even in July in Ohio nights were cold at 4:30 am and I take the credit of inventing with our group newspaper as blankets. Once three of us were stuck in a small town without enough money for a hotel and I ask at the police station if we could sleep in their yard. No dice said the captain. So we asked at an old couples house nearby and slept on their porch, The older lady made us supper but had her son who was head of the Ohio Prison system stop by to check us out. His last name was Rice I recall. That's the only name I recall from our travels.

Too bad we can't remember names like writer Jack Kerouac in his novel " On the Road". In chapters two through seven old Jack must have met about fifty interesting characters while hitching, and remembered them enough later to describe their families, clothes, idiosyncrasies and philosophies.

It's funny how travel writers like Jack Kerouac, Bill Bryson or Paul Theroux always sit next to the most interesting and unusual hobos and eccentrics, remember their names and bio's and on each trip make lifelong dear friends of people they sat with while hitchhiking or in the second class seats on a cross county train.

Since now in 2021 I have few friends I dearly wish I had obtained the names of all the drivers we hitch hiked with, all the pretty girls we flirted with and all the interesting characters we mesmerized with our opinions and travel stories. Perhaps I should have sent the Rice family from southern Ohio Christmas cards over the years. If only I could remember the small southern Ohio town they lived in.

SUMMER SKIES · MIDNIGHT WATCH · 2010

Meteor Shower

The kids in the neighborhood often joked about Mr. Dewitt who dragged a lawn chair into the middle of the back yard and then stayed up all night watching for meteors. He took a quart of beer out there and would watch until a little drunk he dozed off until at about 4AM the cold drove him into his house. Sometimes he would sleep through the morning cold and they would see him on their way to school and joke about it up past the second corner. Not a dignified thing for a 60 year old man to do.

Mr. Dewitt sat in the backyard and thought about the two girls. He worked at the hotel when he was nineteen and he rushed out near the overhang near the front door about 11PM to get someone to move the car. It was an expensive car but he rushed just the same and do his duties planning on yelling a little to clear the entrance to the hotel that he was in charge of for the next 8 hours. The two girls leaning on the car were very pretty, too pretty to pick a favorite. One thing lead to another and the two bored 18 year co-eds ended sleeping in lawn chairs out by the hotel pool.

Mr. Dewitt, as the young man, took out a blanket to the girls and the three of them sat in one lawn chair and watched meteors. Just watched meteors but all three slept a while together even Mr. Dewitt who was supposed to be watching the desk at the hotel even at 3:45AM. About five thirty they went into the lobby of the hotel and he used his key to the restaurant and found them a little something for breakfast.

After watching meteors all night Mr. Dewitt hears the children going to school even over the old music on his MP-3 player as he wakes up in the middle of his backyard a little hung over from watching meteors and stiff and cold in the damp morning air.

KINDNESS OF STRANGERS · AKRON · 2010

The Good Policeman

I was just watching, observing. A baby girl was learning how to talk and the very young Grandfather was fascinated and brimming with desire to share the miracle with the world. He told the policeman he had four grandchildren. I heard that part.

The baby girl's Mother had left her with her Father while she went from McDonald's, where I was here, to Target, to get a wedding gift for her friend. I heard that.

The crowd at the play area at McDonald's all had their own children of various ages. They politely listened to the baby girl saying her few new words. The baby had a lot of personality. She noticed the other kids had their shoes off and wanted to take hers off too.

The policeman had his uniform on but I don't think he was on duty. He just happened to be there at McDonald's. He spent about five minutes listening to the baby talk and drew me into the conversation, introducing me and the grandfather, neither of who he knew five minutes ago.

About two years later I was substitute teaching at an inner city school in my home town. I was in a class room on a break, a planning period, and I heard someone lecturing a kid in the hall who was cutting class and didn't have a pass. The adult lecturer was direct with the kid but caring and kind also.

When the adult lecturing the kid walked past the door of the room I was in, I saw it was the same policeman, in uniform, from the McDonald's two years ago. Later I walked up to him in the halls and said hello.

A GRANDFATHER'S WISDOM · QUAKER SQUARE · 2017

A Grandfather's First Birthday Wishes

Ordered by your Mother not to buy you a present for your first birthday party today I'll impart advice to sit with the Love and comfort I give each time I am blessed fortunate enough to spend a few hours chasing you about as you perfect your walking and understanding. Fret not little King I'll slip you a cookie, vegan of course, with no sugar the next time we exchange vowel sounds standing in front of a mirror down at Quaker Square were we spent some time together way back in early Winter 2016 before the oat silos where torn down, you grew into a man, and I disappeared into your distant memory.

First listen more than you talk to those around you during this the next year as you face the daunting and extremely fascinating challenge of learning to talk to be understood and hearing to understand. From your Mother's parents may you harvest eternal curiosity with the nuances of words and symbols, spoken, written and sung and the intricacies between our language, our dreams, our Culture and the invisible Universe that sometimes is easy to forget and difficult to understand.

For your tenth Birthday Love and worship your Mother and smile kindly at your Father when you best him in a race. Play the piano with your uncle and grandmother when they sing you happy birthday. When you are twelve sleep outside on hard ground in the wind and cold, capture breakfast food from a Lake or stream and tramp joyously about the hills and valleys enclosing your environment.

For your nineteenth year be polite to your elders, kind to your girlfriend and respectful of your neighbors. Stay busy, value rare time alone, and stop and brush snow off your Mother's car in an early morning winter storm.

SOLITUDE & NIGHT WALKS · EAST CANTON · 2020

The Train Doesn't Run to Gettysburg Anymore

The owner told us the train doesn't run to Gettysburg any more a while back so we walk back and forth from East Canton, Ohio over to Gettysburg, Pa on old route 30 with all the paraphernalia for our small circus. The townies don't like circus folks so mostly we travel at night.

Sometimes I walk with the two white elephants for company me being lonely a lot. I enjoy a clear sky for stargazing but a light rain is more than fine also. The rain on the hilly pavement is good companionship and is nice white noise to the clump of the elephants steady steps. Hannibal got elephants over the Alps in winter.

Usually I wear a small backpack with my personal items in it and carry a small old fashion slate chalkboard and two pieces of yellow chalk to write myself important notes of things I don't want to forget.

There isn't much traffic on 30 these days but a couple of years ago I remember a car went whizzing by with a song on the radio by old Tampa Red "when things go wrong with you it hurts me too"; ever since I often hear that old song in my head when I am walking at night. Tampa Red was light skinned and often played a kazoo along with his primitive slide guitar.

If we are trudging up a long hill on a dark night sometimes I will write down a girls name I used to know with my chalk I carry on my small chalk board so I don't forget her and then when I get to the top of the grade I eventually erase her name and put the chalk and chalk board back in my backpack. Doctors say its good for the heart to walk up long steep hills course they do it themselves in a nice car.

Later tonight we should cross the Ohio river on the Jennings bridge. Route 30 only runs for four miles in West Virginia so that part of the trip is a short walk. Coming or going R 30 in WV is no trouble at all.

OLD-SCHOOL HOSPITALITY · SUNDAY DINNER · 2011

Lunch with the Phillips Family

I had an appointment for lunch with the Phillips family. It was an enjoyable hour but, it ended abruptly.

Mr. Phillips was a host from the old school and I was treated very well as we dined. The daughter, a pretty dark eyed girl of about fourteen carried the food to us and was bewitchingly shy as she scurried back and forth from the Kitchen. We sat in the yard under a grape arbor and the son who was in training to learn the Father's duties at the business sat at the table with us men. From time to Time Mr. Phillips would coach the boy a little and once after we went back to the high stone walls I heard Mr. Phillips get a little stern with his son when he didn't think I could hear.

Of course I had to pay for my lunch and the service after and that was handled discretely by the wife. She brought my dessert in a timely manner and a small card contained a bill for the services provided by the Phillips family.

The Father and I spent a few minutes there at the table after lunch talking politics and philosophy and Mr. Phillips offered me a cigar that I declined. I might have made a little trouble by giving it to the son who was about eighteen..

Back at the Stone wall at the rear of the property I played my part perfectly as I walked ahead of the Father and son and pretended to examine some of the fittings between the stones; having once been in the construction business in my youth.

The son must have fired the rifle for the bullet was a little high as it struck me up on my shoulder blades rather than entering the heart from the back as planned. I didn't hear that shot as I fell but I distinctly heard the second shot probably fired by the Father to finish the job. After I died I heard the Father scolding the boy about missing his shot as they walked back up toward the grape arbor to help the wife prepare for their next appointment. It was interesting to hear the Father lecturing the boy on professionalism and the need for having pride in one's work.

WINTER IN OHIO · THE INDUSTRIAL DISTRICT · 2011

Heavy, Heavy Snow

I was rushing through the old industrial district of town. It had been over twenty years since I had been here, before. The element of danger inherent in this bad neighborhood was no longer present to me. I climbed and slid over stalled cars, half buried buses and incapacitated buildings and stores as I rushed along battling the drifted snow.

I had to get to where the young girl was. I didn't know why. The snow was an obstacle to my progress but worse was not knowing where to go although I moved forward with purpose despite the snow. The inhabitants of this section of town were oblivious to me. I moved through their labors digging out cars from the snow piles or struggling with stalled buses and complaining passengers. I moved invisibly through the deep snow; to them at least.

I tried several futile things to move faster in the deep deep snow. Near a run down factory I stood on a heavy iron pair of wheels connected by a rusty axle; I was approaching a steep decent as I ran the narrow roads through this area. I considered standing on the axle and balancing faster down the hills through here. Later I looked for pieces of discarded wood to use as skis. For once in my life I didn't considered rules or consequences, I took or used anything that would facilitate me accomplishing my secret purposes.

At last I rushed into a small apartment in a seedy neighborhood. The door was wide open and the wind was driving the falling snow across the floors of the living room and kitchen where the people stood. A pretty young girl tilted her head to a kiss a young man. I watched intently. Most of the people there were indifferent to the kissing couple and no one noticed me. I walked in and through the crowd. The movement and habits of the girl kissing the young man were infinitely intimately familiar to me.

The young man was myself. Walking back invisibly into the snow I asked the man at the door " where do I go next". He took no notice of me so I continued to walk directionless through the ancient industrial district of the city. Later I began to see more and more troops entering the area.

GROWING UP · SAINT FRANCIS & THE BEATLES · 2016

My Lost Saints

Not being Catholic or anything like that I don't know much about Saints, though always did I admire truly Saint Francis of Assisi from the Giotto painting " Renunciation of Saint Francis' Father", renunciation being intimately familiar to me having lost my best friend over money in a more round about gradual manner myself.

To me however my lost saints will always be The Beatles the big brothers I never had, the man about town I never was and over night success I never came to be, me wanting to be a writer and poet in the Lennon and McCartney tradition. Then came the revelations about Yoko and John's mean drunk drinking in NYC, Paul being mysteriously dead over and over on Album covers I listened to but never actually bought, George being a tad over the top with the mystical stuff, even for me an impractical egg headed dreamer, and finally after John's tragic death reality set in that my Saints had fallen and I was stuck facing a hostile world alone.

A few weeks ago I was commenting to a pretty young girl at the grocery check out, flirting a bit to her who was wearing a Beatles pin on her blouse, she who had been to see Paul perform in Cleveland recently that despite my admiration for the Lads none of them had ever called me, stopped to acknowledge my existence or even criticized my mentioning them in my mostly unread writings. The pretty young girl she just didn't understand where I was coming from.

So not unlike Elizabeth Barrett Browning a fellow Poet who in Sonnet 43 " How do I love thee" wrote the best love poem since Shakespeare I now have lost my Saints [and loves] and my challenge is to find the divinity in myself as I come to realize I am my lost Saint letting slip away my potential as the spark of divinity sacredly placed in myself once by unseen hands wanes with age as I sojourn alone trudging along seeking significance in the face and smile of a grandchild or troubles of one of my children.

Skyward this week did I gaze at a full moon 30 times brighter than usual next visible at this luminosity long after I be gone and forgotten, Venus lighting the coming interminable autumn night and as I hear it universes without end drifting further apart as time slowly grinds on. Me with the audacity to wish for significance in personal being and remembrance as a speck of matter once possessing a spark of insight into stone cold Reality. I am my lost Saints. C'est dommage.